in a big city like Delhi, it could certainly overwhelm the capital's health infrastructure. The good news so far is that India's current recovery rate is 96.36 per cent and fatality rates too are much lower than those observed during the devastating Delta surge.

WHY IS OMICRON LESS LETHAL?

To understand why Omicron has so far proved less lethal than Delta, scientists have been trying to study its progression in lab settings. Researchers at Washington University in St Louis, US, found that Omicron-infected hamsters and mice showed 10 times lower concentration of the variant in the lungs than with Delta. Researchers at the Leuven University in Belgium and the University of Liverpool, UK, made similar observations. "Studies and experiences are suggesting that Omicron infects the upper respiratory tract more and there is less chance of it triggering pneumonia," says Dr Davindra Kundra, pulmonologist at the Manipal Hospital in Dwarka, Delhi.

Another reason for Omicron's reduced impact relates to the memory retention of T-cells, the primary weapon of the human body's immune system. White blood cells that can remember past diseases, they attack virus-infected cells or produce antibodies to counter them. Unlike antibodies, T-cells can target the entire spike protein, which hasn't mutated beyond recognition in Omicron. This was confirmed in a December 10, 2021, study in BioRxiv, which showed that Omicron has not evolved enough to escape the clutches of human T-cells. These cells recognise and help clear Omicron infections before they reach the lower respiratory tract. T-cell memory in Indians could be both due to vaccination and previous Covid infection.

Yet a lot remains unknown about Omicron and its impact. "Most patients are less likely to see severe disease with Omicron," says Dr Kundra. "But one cannot rule it out entirely yet. Moreover, some patients with mild symptoms in the previous waves had long Covid symptoms. We don't know yet whether that will happen with Omicron." More than 50 long-term effects of Covid-19 have been detected from around the world. The most common symptoms that can last from four to 12 weeks after acute infection are headache, fatigue, disturbed sleep, lack of concentration and body pain. Those with more severe Covid have had sudden blood clots, strokes, heart attacks and even kidney failure after recovery. "It is still too soon to ascertain how Omicron will impact human health post recovery," says Dr V.K. Bahl, principal director of cardiac sciences at Max Healthcare in Saket, Delhi.

KNOW YOUR VARIANT

What to expect when Omicron comes calling, when to confirm if you are positive and how to beat the infection



OMICRON SYMPTOMS

- According to a CDC study, the four most common Omicron symptoms are cold, fatigue, nasal congestion and runny nose
- An ongoing study by King's College London also lists nausea, loss of appetite and night sweats as symptoms. It also reports that 1 in 50 is likely to get long-term health complications post Omicron



WHEN TO TEST

- Doctors advise a test as soon as any symptom appears. This is because treatment efficacy improves if started between Day 3 and 5 after symptom first appears
- RT-PCR test is still the most assured confirmatory diagnosis for Covid



TREATMENT OPTIONS

- People with mild symptoms are advised rest, a light diet, plenty of fluids and only paracetemol to treat fever (in consultation with a doctor)
- Moderate cases may be prescribed an antiviral pill or a monoclonal antibody treatment

WHAT IS THE BEST WAY TO TREAT OMICRON?

Doctors in India advise taking an RT-PCR test as soon as symptoms appear. Home kits using rapid antigen tests (RAT) should be the last resort, not the first, doctors advise. "Collecting the sample from the nasal cavity is not as simple as it looks. You need trained personnel to do it," says Dr Arjun Dang, CEO of Dr Dang's Lab in Delhi. India has the capacity to produce over 12 million ICMR-approved RATs per month. Available on Amazon and other e-commerce sites for as little as Rs 200, they have been flying off the shelves ever since the beginning of the third wave. But these tests have a high probability of false negatives. RT-PCR tests remain the gold standard for Covid-19 diagnosis. In an April 2021 PubMed study, researchers found that rapid tests from four of the biggest global companies accurately predicted Covid-positive results only 44.6-54.9 per cent of the time. In other words,